GRE Text Completion Practice Pack

The 3-Step Systematic Method, Structural Signal Words, Word Pairing & 3-Blank Decomposition

1. The 3-Step Systematic Text Completion Method

Never plug answer choices into the blanks immediately. Follow this 3-step evidence-based approach.

Step Number & Name	Core Analytical Action	Cognitive Objective	Trap to Avoid
Step 1: Read for Sentence Logic	Read the entire sentence ignoring the blanks; locate structural pivot words	Understand the author's overall narrative and logical direction	Plugging in choices to see what "sounds good"
Step 2: Identify Clues & Roadmaps	Underline the exact keywords that define the missing concept	Identify whether the sentence requires a contrast or support word	Relying on subjective impressions rather than textual clues
Step 3: Pre-phrase in Your Own Words	Formulate a simple, everyday word to fill the blank before looking at options	Anchors your mind so you are not swayed by obscure vocabulary distractors	Reading answer choices before forming an independent prediction
Step 4: Match & Eliminate Choices	Compare your pre-phrased word against the 5 (or 3) answer choices	Eliminate options that contradict your predicted tone or meaning	Choosing a high-level word simply because it sounds sophisticated

Scoring Rule: For 2-blank and 3-blank questions, you receive ZERO credit unless ALL blanks are answered correctly!

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2. Structural Signal Words: Contrast vs Support Roadmaps

Train your eyes to detect transition signposts that dictate the logical direction of the blanks.

Signal Category	Keyword Signposts to Circle	Logical Relationship Enforced	Direction of the Blank
Contrast / Shift Signals	Although, However, Despite, In spite of, Yet, Nonetheless, Whereas, Ironically	The blank must oppose or contradict the stated clue in the other clause	Opposite meaning / polarity flip
Support / Continuation Signals	Furthermore, Moreover, In addition, Consequently, Because, Thus, Therefore, Similarly	The blank must reinforce, mirror, or extend the stated clue	Same meaning / consistent polarity
Cause and Effect Signals	Because, Given that, As a result, Consequently, Leads to, Produces	The blank represents the direct consequence or trigger of the cause	Logical causality alignment
Apposition & Colons	Colon (:), Semicolon (;), Dash (—), "That is to say"	The clause following the punctuation restates or clarifies the preceding clause	Direct synonym or definition match

Vocabulary Tip: Focus on learning word polarity (positive, negative, neutral) to eliminate wrong choices rapidly.

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3. Tackling Multi-Blank (2-Blank and 3-Blank) Questions

Specialized techniques to solve complex multi-blank questions without guessing.

- Solve the Easiest Blank First: Never start with Blank 1 automatically. Often, Blank 2 or Blank 3 contains the clearest contextual clue.
- Use Solved Blanks as New Clues: Once you solve Blank 2, treat your pre-phrase as a proven fact to unlock Blank 1.
- Verify Mutual Dependency: Read the complete sentence with your selected words to ensure the narrative flows seamlessly.
- Beware of Secondary Definitions: ETS frequently tests words like "pedestrian" (ordinary/dull), "plastic" (moldable), or "qualify" (limit/moderate).